A HISTORICAL AND NEW TESTAMENT COMPANION

Highlights of Turkey

The places on the route, the peoples who lived in them, the powers that fought over them, and where they meet the New Testament.

Istanbul · Cappadocia · Konya · Hierapolis · Laodicea · Ephesus · the Bosphorus

15–24 OCTOBER 2026
TEN DAYS · TWENTY-FIVE STOPS

AN INDEPENDENT COMPANION TO THE
BOUNTIFUL TRAVEL TOUR WITH BRENT L. TOP

CONTENTS

Twenty-five stops, in travelling order

Each stop has its own section with the same four parts: the **history** of the place, the **people** who lived there, the **power and politics** around it at the time, and a **New Testament** note with the passages that name the place or bear on what you will see. Most sections end with key dates and things to look for on site.

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GOOD TO KNOW ON THE GROUND

- **Hagia Sophia** is a working mosque. Since January 2024 foreign visitors follow a ticketed route through the upper gallery, where the mosaics are, and look down into the prayer hall.
- **Kariye (Chora)** reopened in May 2024, also as a mosque. The mosaics of the two entrance halls and the frescoes of the side chapel are on view; three mosaics in the prayer hall are curtained.
- **In mosques**, shoes come off, shoulders and knees are covered, and women cover their hair. Visits pause around the five daily prayers and at midday on Friday.
- **Derinkuyu** means low, narrow, steep tunnels. Anyone uneasy in tight spaces can wait at the surface without missing the point of the place.
- **Ephesus** is a long downhill walk on polished marble that is slippery even when dry. The Pamukkale terraces are walked barefoot.
- **Cappadocia** sits above 1,000 metres. Dawn in late October is cold, especially in a balloon basket.

Also in this guide: the route and itinerary at a glance, Anatolia in nine eras, and the peoples you will keep meeting (next three pages); a scripture finder for every stop, further reading and sources (at the back).

THE ROUTE

A loop through Anatolia



By road By air Route lines are schematic.

ITINERARY AT A GLANCE

DAY	DATE	WHERE	WHAT IS VISITED	SECTIONS
1	Thu 15 Oct	In transit	Overnight flight to Istanbul	—
2	Fri 16 Oct	Istanbul	Arrival; optional Çemberlitaş Hamamı	01–02
3	Sat 17 Oct	Istanbul	Hippodrome, Hagia Sophia, Topkapı Palace, Blue Mosque, Basilica Cistern, Grand Bazaar; Whirling Dervish ceremony	03–09
4	Sun 18 Oct	Istanbul → Cappadocia	Kariye (Chora); flight to Cappadocia	10–11
5	Mon 19 Oct	Cappadocia	Optional balloon; Derinkuyu, Avanos, Göreme Open-Air Museum, Uçhisar	12–15
6	Tue 20 Oct	Cappadocia → Pamukkale	Long drive west with a stop at Konya (Mevlana Museum)	16
7	Wed 21 Oct	Pamukkale → Kuşadası	Travertines, Hierapolis and its museum, Laodicea	17–19
8	Thu 22 Oct	Ephesus	Temple of Artemis, Ephesus and the Terrace Houses, Basilica of St John, carpet village	20–23
9	Fri 23 Oct	Izmir → Istanbul	Flight from Izmir; Spice Bazaar, Bosphorus cruise	24–25
10	Sat 24 Oct	In transit	Flight home	—

ORIENTATION

Anatolia in nine eras

Anatolia, the peninsula the Romans called Asia Minor, is a land bridge between Europe, the Caucasus, Mesopotamia and the Levant. Every power that wanted to move between them had to hold it, which is why the same sites were built on, conquered and rebuilt by one people after another.

ERA	DATES	WHO HELD POWER	WHERE YOU MEET IT ON THIS TOUR
First farmers and the Bronze Age	to c. 1200 BC	Neolithic towns such as Çatalhöyük; later the Hittite Empire, ruling from Hattusa, and the kingdom of Arzawa in the west	The Konya plain; Avanos pottery; the hill at Selçuk, probably the Hittite-era city of Apasa
Iron Age kingdoms	c. 1200–546 BC	Phrygia in the interior, Lydia at Sardis, and Greek (Ionian) city-states along the Aegean	Temple of Artemis; the cult cave at Hierapolis; the Halys river at Avanos
Persian rule	546–334 BC	The Achaemenid kings, through governors (satraps); the Greek cities pay tribute	The name "Cappadocia"; the Serpent Column in the Hippodrome
Hellenistic kingdoms	334–133 BC	Alexander, then his successors: Seleucids, the Attalids of Pergamon, a native kingdom in Cappadocia	Hierapolis and Laodicea are founded; Ephesus is moved to its present site
Rome	133 BC–AD 330	The Republic, then the emperors. The west is the province of Asia; the interior is Galatia and Cappadocia	Ephesus as it stands; Laodicea; the Hippodrome; the journeys of Paul
The Eastern Roman (Byzantine) Empire	330–1453	Christian emperors in Constantinople, Greek in language, Roman in law. They lose most of Anatolia after 1071	Hagia Sophia, the Cistern, Kariye, Derinkuyu, Göreme, the Basilica of St John
Seljuks and emirates	1071–c. 1400	The Seljuk Sultanate of Rum at Konya; Crusaders pass through; the Mongols arrive in 1243; then rival Turkish emirates	Konya and Rumi; caravanserais; the İsa Bey Mosque at Selçuk
The Ottoman Empire	c. 1299–1922	The house of Osman, in Constantinople from 1453, ruling from Hungary to Yemen at its height	Topkapı, the Blue Mosque, the bazaars and baths, Rumeli Fortress, Dolmabahçe
The Republic	1923–today	A secular nation-state founded by Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, with its capital at Ankara	The museums; the changing status of Hagia Sophia and Kariye; Atatürk's room at Dolmabahçe

A NOTE ON NAMES

"Byzantine" is a label invented in western Europe after the empire fell. Its people called themselves Romans, and so did their neighbours: the Seljuks named their state the Sultanate of *Rum*, meaning Rome, and the poet Rumi's name means "the Roman". This guide uses "Byzantine" because the sites do, and writes Türkiye's name in its familiar English form, as the tour does.

The peoples you will keep meeting

Hittites. An Indo-European people who built the first Anatolian empire (c. 1650–1180 BC) from the central plateau. They fought Egypt to a draw at Kadesh and left the earliest written references to the Aegean coast.

Phrygians and Lydians. Iron Age kingdoms of the interior and the west. Phrygia gave the Greeks the legends of Midas and the mother goddess Cybele. Lydia, under Croesus, struck some of the world's first coins and conquered the Greek coast.

Ionians. Greeks who settled the Aegean shore from about 1000 BC. Their twelve cities, Ephesus among them, produced the first Greek philosophers and historians while living under Lydian and then Persian overlords.

Persians. Rulers of Anatolia for two centuries. They governed lightly, through local elites, and left Persian-descended nobles and fire-priests in Cappadocia long after Alexander.

Galatians. Celts from central Europe who crossed into Anatolia in 278 BC and settled around Ankara. The Roman province named after them stretched south to Iconium (Konya).

Jews of Asia Minor. Present in the western cities from at least the third century BC, when the Seleucid king Antiochus III settled two thousand Jewish families in Lydia and Phrygia. Their synagogues were where Paul began in each city.

Romans and "Romans". Italian governors, soldiers and businessmen from 133 BC; later, every free inhabitant of the empire. The Greek-speaking Christians of medieval Anatolia kept the name until the twentieth century, as *Rum*.

Armenians. An ancient Christian nation of the eastern highlands, prominent in Byzantine armies and, under the Ottomans, as merchants, craftsmen and court architects. Dolmabahçe Palace is the work of one Armenian family.

Seljuk Turks. Turkic nomads from Central Asia who adopted Islam and Persian court culture, defeated Byzantium at Manzikert in 1071 and made Konya their capital. With them Anatolia began to become Turkish-speaking and Muslim.

Mongols. They broke Seljuk power in 1243. The refugees they drove west included the family of Rumi, and the vacuum they left allowed small frontier emirates, including the Ottomans, to grow.

Ottomans. A dynasty, not an ethnic group. Its ruling class was drawn from converts of Balkan, Caucasian and Anatolian origin, and its subjects were organised by religious community (*millet*) under their own leaders.

Karamanlides. Turkish-speaking Orthodox Christians of Cappadocia who wrote Turkish in Greek letters. They were sent to Greece in the population exchange of 1923–24, which ended three thousand years of Greek life in Anatolia.

PART I

DAYS 2–4

Istanbul

Three empires made this their capital. Almost everything on the first two days stands within a fifteen-minute walk on the old city's first hill.

01 Istanbul

Byzantion · Constantinople · Kostantiniyye

DAYS 2–4, 9

A city founded three times, as a Greek colony, a Roman capital and an Ottoman one, on the single piece of ground that commands both the sea road between the Black Sea and the Mediterranean and the land road between Europe and Asia.

HISTORY

Greek colonists from Megara founded Byzantion around 657 BC on the headland where Topkapı Palace now stands. For nearly a thousand years it was a prosperous middling port living on tolls and tuna, passing between Persian, Athenian, Spartan and Macedonian control before becoming a Roman ally and then a Roman possession. Septimius Severus destroyed it in AD 196 for backing a rival, then rebuilt it.

In 324 the emperor Constantine chose it as his new capital and on 11 May 330 dedicated it as New Rome. The land walls of Theodosius II, finished in 413, were not breached for more than a thousand years. Under Justinian (527–565) it was the largest city in Christendom, with perhaps half a million people. It withstood a Persian and Avar siege in 626, Arab sieges in the 670s and in 717–718, and attacks by Bulgars and Rus, only to be stormed across its weaker sea walls in 1204 and looted by the Fourth Crusade, an army of fellow Christians that had set out for Egypt. The Byzantines recovered a ruined, half-empty city in 1261.

On 29 May 1453 the twenty-one-year-old Ottoman sultan Mehmed II broke through the land walls after a seven-week siege. The last emperor, Constantine XI, died in the fighting. Mehmed made the city his capital, and it remained the Ottoman capital for 470 years. After defeat in the First World War it was occupied by the Allies (1918–1923). The new Republic moved the government to Ankara in 1923, and "Istanbul", long the everyday name, became the only official one in 1930. About sixteen million people live here now.

THE PEOPLE

The Byzantines were Greek-speaking Christians who thought of themselves as Romans. Their city also held Armenians, Jews, Norse and later English mercenaries in the emperor's Varangian Guard, and Venetian and Genoese

merchants in walled quarters along the Golden Horn. The Genoese had a town of their own at Galata, across the water.

Mehmed II repopulated the conquered city on purpose, ordering Turks, Greeks, Armenians and Jews to move in from across his empire. In 1492 his son Bayezid II took in the Sephardic Jews expelled from Spain. Each religious community ran its own courts, schools and charities under its own head. As late as the 1880s about half the city's population was not Muslim.

The twentieth century ended that. War, the 1923 population exchange (from which Istanbul's Greeks were formally exempt), a punitive wealth tax in 1942 and anti-Greek riots in 1955 reduced the old minorities to a few tens of thousands. Mass migration from rural Anatolia since the 1950s made the modern city.

POWER AND POLITICS

The city's history is its geography. Whoever holds it can close the Bosphorus. In the fifth century BC that meant control of the Black Sea grain that fed Athens; in the nineteenth and twentieth it meant control of Russia's only route to warm water. It was also the western end of the caravan roads from Persia and China.

So the city's enemies changed, but there were always enemies: Sasanian Persia and the Arab caliphates for the Byzantines, then Normans, Venetians and Turks; Habsburg Austria, Safavid Persia and Russia for the Ottomans. In the nineteenth century Britain and France propped up a weakening Ottoman state to keep Russia out of the straits. The Montreux Convention of 1936, which gives Turkey control over warships passing through, is still in force.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · Acts 16:7–11 · Romans 16:9 · 1 Peter 1:1

Byzantium is never mentioned in the New Testament, but the apostles' world surrounded it. Across the strait lay Bithynia, which Paul tried to enter and was turned away from: "they assayed to go into Bithynia: but the Spirit suffered them not" (Acts 16:7). Its Christians were among those Peter addressed in his first letter (1 Peter 1:1).

Byzantine tradition, developed from the seventh century on, held that the apostle Andrew preached here and made Stachys, whom Paul greets as "Stachys my beloved" (Romans 16:9), the city's first bishop. The story gave New Rome an apostolic founder to set beside Rome's Peter, Andrew's brother. In the 350s Constantine's son brought relics venerated as those of Timothy, Andrew and Luke to the city's Church of the Holy Apostles.

The city also shaped the text you read. The Byzantine church copied the Greek New Testament for a thousand years, and the late manuscripts Erasmus used for his printed Greek New Testament of 1516, the basis of the text behind the King James Version, came out of that tradition.

KEY DATES

c. 657 BC	Byzantion founded by Greeks from Megara
AD 330	Constantine dedicates the city as his capital
1204	Sack by the Fourth Crusade; a Latin emperor rules until 1261
1453	Ottoman conquest under Mehmed II
1923	The Republic is declared and the capital moves to Ankara

02

Çemberlitaş Hamamı

and the Column of Constantine beside it

DAY 2 · OPTIONAL

A sixteenth-century bathhouse still doing what it was built for, named after the oldest monument of Constantine's city, which stands at its door.

HISTORY

The bath was built in 1584 on an endowment of Nurbanu Sultan and is attributed to Sinan, the chief imperial architect. Its income supported her mosque complex across the water in Üsküdar. It is a double bath, with matching men's and women's halls, each a domed hot room around a heated marble platform. Part of the women's side was cut away when the street was widened in the 1860s.

The name means "bath of the hooped stone". The hooped stone is the Column of Constantine just outside: drums of purple Egyptian porphyry raised in 330 at the centre of Constantine's new forum and originally topped by a statue of the emperor in the guise of the sun god. The statue blew down in a storm in 1106. Iron hoops have held the cracked drums together since late antiquity, and a fire in 1779 left it the blackened shaft you see.

THE PEOPLE

Nurbanu was a slave who became the most powerful woman in the empire. By the usual account she was a Venetian noblewoman's daughter captured in the Aegean as a child. She became the consort of Selim II and then, as mother of Murad III, the first of the queen mothers who dominated Ottoman politics for the next century.

The bath itself is a Roman institution that the Turks inherited through Byzantium and adapted to Islamic rules of ritual washing: running water poured from basins, never a shared plunge pool. For Ottoman women, who had few public spaces, the weekly bath was where news was exchanged and marriages were arranged.

POWER AND POLITICS

The 1580s were close to the Ottoman high-water mark. Cyprus had just been taken from Venice, the naval defeat at Lepanto (1571) had been made good within a year, and a long war with Persia was under way. Nurbanu corresponded with the Venetian government and with Catherine de' Medici in France, and Venice thought her influence worth cultivating with gifts.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · legends link the column to Matthew 14:13–21 · Mark 14:3

Later Byzantine legend held that Constantine buried sacred objects in the column's foundation: fragments of the cross, the baskets of leftovers from the feeding of the five thousand (Matthew 14:13–21; John 6:1–13), and the alabaster box of ointment poured over Jesus at Bethany (Mark 14:3). No one has dug to check. The legend shows how the new capital wanted to be seen: as a Christian Rome holding the memory of the gospels at its centre.

03

The Hippodrome

Sultanahmet Meydanı · At Meydanı, "Horse Square"

DAY 3 · SAT 17 OCT

The chariot track of Constantinople, where emperors faced their people. The park follows its outline, and three monuments still stand along the line of its central barrier.

HISTORY

Septimius Severus began the track around AD 203 and Constantine enlarged it to rival the Circus Maximus in Rome: about 450 metres long, with seating for tens of thousands. The racing surface lies four to five metres below today's paving. Races continued into the twelfth century. The crusaders stripped the stadium in 1204, and by the Ottoman conquest it was a ruin used as a quarry.

The **Egyptian Obelisk** was carved for Pharaoh Thutmose III about 1450 BC and stood at Karnak. It was shipped down the Nile in the fourth century and set up here in 390 by Theodosius I. What you see is roughly the upper two-thirds; the rest broke in transit. Its marble base shows Theodosius and his court watching the races from the imperial box.

The **Serpent Column** is the oldest Greek monument in the city. It was cast from captured Persian bronze after the Greek victory at Plataea in 479 BC and stood at Delphi for eight hundred years, three intertwined snakes holding a golden tripod. The names of thirty-one Greek cities are cut into the coils. Constantine brought it here; the heads were broken off around 1700.

The third monument, which the itinerary calls the Column of Constantine, is the **Walled Obelisk**, a masonry pillar of unknown date that the emperor Constantine VII repaired in the tenth century and sheathed in gilded bronze. The crusaders took the bronze. They also took the four gilded horses that stood above the starting gates; these are now at St Mark's in Venice.

THE PEOPLE

The crowd was organised into racing clubs, the Blues and the Greens, which doubled as street gangs and something like political parties. In January 532 the two united against Justinian. The Nika riots ("Conquer!" was the racing chant) burned half the city, including the cathedral. Justinian prepared to flee. According to the

historian Procopius the empress Theodora refused to go, and his generals then trapped the rioters inside the Hippodrome and killed about thirty thousand of them.

Under the Ottomans this was the Horse Square, the setting for royal circumcision feasts, guild parades and more than one mutiny by the Janissaries.

POWER AND POLITICS

The Hippodrome was the one place where the ruler and the people met. Emperors were acclaimed here, generals held triumphs here, and an unpopular emperor heard about it here. The monuments made a political claim of their own: by collecting trophies from Egypt, Delphi and Rome, the new capital presented itself as heir to every earlier empire.

The domed fountain at the north end is a later piece of diplomacy, a gift from Kaiser Wilhelm II after his visit in 1898, when Germany was courting the Ottomans. That courtship ended in the alliance of 1914.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · 1 Corinthians 9:24–27 · 2 Timothy 4:7–8 · Hebrews 12:1 · Acts 16:16 · 18:12

Paul and the writer of Hebrews reached for the stadium to describe the Christian life. “Know ye not that they which run in a race run all, but one receiveth the prize? So run, that ye may obtain” (1 Corinthians 9:24). Near the end Paul wrote, “I have finished my course” (2 Timothy 4:7), and Hebrews pictures believers running before “so great a cloud of witnesses” (12:1), the packed stands of a stadium like this one. Their images are of foot races rather than chariots, but the crowd and the prize were the same.

The Serpent Column stood for eight centuries at Delphi, the shrine of Pythian Apollo. When Acts describes the slave girl at Philippi “possessed with a spirit of divination”, the Greek says literally “a spirit of a python”, the title of Delphi’s prophetess (Acts 16:16). An inscription found at Delphi naming the governor Gallio is the key to dating Paul’s stay at Corinth (Acts 18:12) to about AD 51–52.

KEY DATES

479 BC	Serpent Column dedicated at Delphi
c. AD 203	Track begun by Septimius Severus
390	Obelisk raised by Theodosius I
532	Nika riots
1204	Crusaders loot the stadium

LOOK FOR

- ◇ The reliefs on the obelisk’s base: the emperor holding the victor’s wreath, with dancers and an organ below
- ◇ The sunken pits around each monument, which show the original ground level
- ◇ The curve of the street at the south end, which follows the track’s rounded turn

04 Hagia Sophia

Ayasofya · the Church of the Holy Wisdom

DAY 3 · SAT 17 OCT

For nine centuries the largest church in the Christian world, then for five centuries the chief mosque of the Ottoman Empire. Every regime that has held the city has remade the building as a statement about itself.

HISTORY

This is the third church on the site. The first was dedicated in 360 and the second in 415; rioters burned the second during the Nika revolt of 532. Within weeks Justinian commissioned a replacement from Anthemius of Tralles and Isidore of Miletus, a mathematician and a physicist with no buildings to their names. Some ten thousand workers finished it in under six years, and it was dedicated in December 537.

The design placed a dome 31 metres across on four arches so that it appears to float above a ring of windows. It was too ambitious: the first dome fell in 558 after a run of earthquakes. Isidore's nephew rebuilt it steeper, and that dome, patched twice since, still stands 56 metres above the floor.

This was the church of the patriarch and the coronation church of the emperors. In 1054 papal envoys laid a bull of excommunication on its altar, the moment conventionally taken as the split between the Catholic and Orthodox churches. In 1204 the crusaders looted it and made it a Latin cathedral for fifty-seven years.

Mehmed II converted it to a mosque on the day he entered the city in 1453. The minarets were added over the next century and Sinan buttressed the walls in the 1570s. The great calligraphic roundels date from a restoration of the 1840s. In 1934 Atatürk's government made it a museum. In July 2020 a Turkish court annulled that decision and it became a mosque again.

THE PEOPLE

The building recorded those who used it. Emperors and empresses appear in the gallery mosaics, offering purses of gold to Christ. A Norse guardsman scratched his name, Halfdan, into the marble balustrade in runes. Envoys from Vladimir of Kyiv, sent in 987 to compare religions, reported that during the service they could not tell whether they were in heaven or on earth; the conversion of the Rus followed. Enrico Dandolo, the blind doge of Venice who steered the Fourth Crusade to Constantinople, was buried in the gallery.

The figural mosaics all date from after 843. For most of the century before that, emperors who held that images were idols had them destroyed. This was the Iconoclast controversy, which split Byzantine society and deepened the divide with Rome.

POWER AND POLITICS

Justinian built at the height of his ambition. In the same years his armies retook North Africa and invaded Italy to restore the western empire, and his lawyers codified Roman law. The church was the visible sign of that programme, and its cost was part of what left his successors unable to hold his conquests.

Each later change of status was just as political: Mehmed's conversion announced a new imperial power; the museum of 1934 announced a secular republic looking west; the reconversion of 2020 announced a government that grounds its legitimacy in the Ottoman and Islamic past.

NEW TESTAMENT

1 Corinthians 1:24 · John 1:29 · John 8:12 · 20:19 · Colossians 1:15

The church was dedicated not to a saint named Sophia but to Christ as the Wisdom of God, after Paul's phrase "Christ the power of God, and the wisdom of God" (1 Corinthians 1:24).

The Deësis mosaic in the south gallery shows Christ between Mary and John the Baptist, who intercede for humanity. John is the forerunner who pointed to Jesus with the words "Behold the Lamb of God, which taketh away the sin of the world" (John 1:29). Over the central door from the entrance hall, if it is in view, Christ holds a book that reads "Peace be unto you. I am the light of the world", joining John 20:19 and 8:12.

The Iconoclast controversy, which explains why every figural mosaic is late, was at bottom an argument about the New Testament: whether the God made visible in Christ, "the image of the invisible God" (Colossians 1:15), could rightly be painted.

KEY DATES

537	Justinian's church dedicated
558–562	Dome collapses and is rebuilt
1054	Excommunication laid on the altar
1453	Converted to a mosque
1934	Declared a museum
2020	Becomes a mosque again

LOOK FOR, FROM THE UPPER GALLERY

- ◇ The Deësis mosaic of about 1261: Christ between Mary and John the Baptist, with faces modelled like paintings
- ◇ The imperial panels: Empress Zoë with Constantine IX, and John II Komnenos with Empress Irene
- ◇ Halfdan's runes on the south gallery balustrade, and Dandolo's grave marker nearby
- ◇ The view down the nave to the apse, where the mosque's prayer niche sits off-centre so that it faces Mecca

05

Topkapı Palace

Topkapı Sarayı · seat of the sultans, c. 1465–1856

DAY 3 · SAT 17 OCT

The headquarters of an empire on three continents, laid out as a sequence of walled courtyards, each more private than the last.

HISTORY

Mehmed II began the palace in 1459 on the acropolis of ancient Byzantion. It was known as the New Palace; "Topkapı", meaning Cannon Gate, is a nineteenth-century nickname. The plan follows the layout of a Turkish royal camp rather than a European palace: low pavilions around four courts.

The First Court was open to anyone and still contains Hagia Eirene, a sixth-century church that the Ottomans used as an armoury and never converted. The Second held the council chamber and kitchens that fed four thousand people a day. The Third was the sultan's own: the audience hall, the treasury, the palace school and the rooms that hold relics of the Prophet. The Fourth is a garden of kiosks above the water. The Harem, the family quarters, grew alongside from the late 1500s.

Some twenty-five sultans lived here. In 1856 the court moved to Dolmabahçe (section 25). In 1924 the Republic opened the palace as a museum, one of its first acts.

THE PEOPLE

The palace was staffed, and the empire largely governed, by slaves. Under the *devşirme*, a levy on Christian villages in the Balkans, boys were taken, converted and educated. The ablest went to the palace school and rose to be generals and grand viziers; the rest filled the Janissary corps. For two centuries most of the sultan's chief ministers had been born Serbian, Albanian, Greek or Bosnian Christians.

The women of the Harem were slaves too, mostly from the Caucasus and the Black Sea steppe. Hürrem, known in Europe as Roxelana, was captured in what is now Ukraine and became the legal wife of Süleyman the Magnificent. The Harem was ruled by the sultan's mother and guarded by African eunuchs, whose chief was one of the highest officers of state.

POWER AND POLITICS

Under Süleyman (1520–1566) the orders issued here ran from the outskirts of Vienna to Yemen and from Algiers to Baghdad. His father's conquest of Egypt in 1517 brought the holy cities of Arabia under Ottoman protection, and with them the relics displayed in the Third Court and the dynasty's claim to lead Sunni Islam.

The empire had two standing rivals, the Habsburgs to the west and the Shia Safavids of Persia to the east, and it balanced them with an alliance with France from 1536. Foreign envoys were led through the courts in silence and received in the audience hall. Europeans came to call the Ottoman government "the Sublime Porte", after the gate where its business was done.

NEW TESTAMENT

Mark 6:17–29 · Matthew 14:3–12 · John 14:27

Among the relics in the Privy Chamber, beside those of the Prophet Muhammad, are a reliquary arm and a fragment of skull venerated as those of John the Baptist, whose execution by Herod Antipas is told in Mark 6:17–29. Islam honours John as the prophet Yahya, which is why the Ottomans kept them with care.

The church of Hagia Eirene, "Holy Peace" (compare John 14:27), in the First Court stands on the site where the bishops of the Council of Constantinople met in 381 and completed the Nicene Creed, the summary of New Testament teaching still recited in most churches.

KEY DATES

1459	Construction begins
1517	Conquest of Egypt; the relics arrive
1520–66	Reign of Süleyman
1856	Court moves to Dolmabahçe
1924	Opened as a museum

LOOK FOR

- ◇ The grilled window above the council chamber, from which the sultan could listen unseen
- ◇ The kitchens' Chinese porcelain, one of the largest collections outside China
- ◇ In the Treasury, the 86-carat Spoonmaker's Diamond and the emerald-hilted Topkapı Dagger
- ◇ The Baghdad Kiosk of 1639 and the view from the Fourth Court across to Asia

06

The Blue Mosque

Sultan Ahmet Camii

DAY 3 · SAT 17 OCT

The last of the great imperial mosques, built by a young sultan to answer Hagia Sophia across the square.

HISTORY

Ahmed I commissioned the mosque in 1609, when he was nineteen, from Sedefkâr Mehmed Ağa, a pupil of Sinan. It rose over the ruins of the Byzantine Great Palace and part of the Hippodrome's seating and was finished in 1617, the year Ahmed died at twenty-seven. He is buried beside it.

The exterior is a cascade of domes and half-domes with six minarets, which caused a scandal because only the mosque at Mecca had as many; the sultan is said to have paid for a seventh there. The interior takes its popular name from more than twenty thousand tiles made at İznik, patterned with tulips, carnations and cypresses, and from the blue paintwork of the upper levels. A long restoration ended in 2023.

THE PEOPLE

Ahmed came to the throne at thirteen and broke with custom by sparing his brother's life, where earlier sultans had their brothers strangled on accession. The change altered the succession for good. His consort Kösem went on to rule as regent for a son and a grandson and became the most powerful woman in Ottoman history.

The tile order was so large that it strained the İznik workshops. The sultan fixed the price and forbade the potters to sell to anyone else, and the industry never recovered its earlier quality.

POWER AND POLITICS

Earlier sultans paid for their mosques from the spoils of conquest. Ahmed had no conquests to draw on. The 1606 peace with Austria was the first in which the sultan treated the Habsburg emperor as an equal. In the east Shah Abbas of Persia took back Tabriz and the Caucasus, and Anatolia itself was torn by provincial revolts. The clergy objected that a mosque paid for from the treasury was improper. Ahmed built it anyway, as a show of piety and confidence in a difficult decade.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · compare John 14:16 · 15:26

Muslims revere Jesus (*ʿIsa*) as a prophet born of the Virgin Mary, and Mary is the only woman named in the Qur'an. The sultan's name has a New Testament connection of its own. The Qur'an (61:6) says Jesus foretold a messenger called Ahmad, and from early on Muslim writers identified him with the "Comforter" whom Jesus promises in John 14:16 and 15:26. Christians read those verses as referring to the Holy Ghost. The two readings of the same verses are a small window into how the two faiths regard each other.

LOOK FOR

- The chain across the western court gate, hung low so that the sultan had to bow his head as he rode in
- The four fluted piers, five metres thick, that carry the dome
- The tile panels in the galleries, where the best work is

07 The Basilica Cistern

Yerebatan Sarnıcı, "the sunken cistern"

DAY 3 · SAT 17 OCT

A reservoir the size of a cathedral, built under the city to make sure it could outlast a siege.

HISTORY

Justinian had the cistern dug after the Nika riots of 532, beneath a colonnaded public square called the Basilica, which gave it its name. It measures about 138 by 65 metres, and its brick vaults rest on 336 columns in twelve rows. Full, it held some eighty thousand cubic metres of water, brought by aqueduct from forests nearly twenty kilometres to the north.

The columns and capitals do not match because they were salvaged from older buildings. Two column bases are giant heads of Medusa, one set sideways and one upside down. They were probably just blocks of the right height, though stories about neutralising her gaze are older than the tourist trade.

After the conquest the cistern watered the gardens of Topkapı and was otherwise forgotten. The French scholar Pierre Gilles found it again in the 1540s after noticing that householders above drew water, and sometimes fish, through holes in their floors. The latest restoration was completed in 2022.

THE PEOPLE

The builders are anonymous; later tradition says seven thousand slaves. The users were the palace and, in emergencies, the whole population of a city that has no river and few springs. Constantinople kept several hundred cisterns, covered and open, some large enough to be football grounds today.

POWER AND POLITICS

Water was a military matter. An enemy could not breach the land walls but could cut the aqueducts, as the Avars did in 626, and the main line stayed dry for well over a century afterwards. Stored water was what allowed the city to sit out one siege after another. The cistern also belongs to Justinian's rebuilding after the riots, a programme meant to show that imperial authority had been restored.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · John 4:10–14 · 7:37–38 · Revelation 22:1, 17

In a city that could die of thirst under siege, stored water meant survival, and the New Testament uses water the same way. Jesus offered the woman at the well water that would be "a well of water springing up into everlasting life" (John 4:14), and the Bible closes with an invitation: "whosoever will, let him take the water of life freely" (Revelation 22:17). Water returns at Laodicea, whose lukewarm supply became a byword in Revelation 3.

08 The Grand Bazaar

Kapalıçarşı, "the covered market"

DAY 3 · SAT 17 OCT

A walled commercial city of some sixty streets and four thousand shops, trading on the same spot since the 1450s.

HISTORY

Within a few years of the conquest Mehmed II ordered a *bedesten*, a domed and lockable hall for goods of high value, to restart the city's trade. It still stands at the centre of the market as the İç Bedesten. A second hall followed, the lanes between and around them were roofed, and by the seventeenth century the bazaar had its present extent. Fires and earthquakes levelled parts of it many times; much of what you see dates from repairs after the earthquake of 1894.

The rents were assigned as a religious endowment to the upkeep of the Hagia Sophia mosque.

THE PEOPLE

Each trade had its guild and each guild its street. The names survive: the Street of the Fur-Cap Makers, of the Jewellers, of the Fez Makers. Guilds fixed quality and prices, and for centuries the market did without advertising or display: goods were kept in cupboards and brought out on request. The merchants were Turks, Greeks, Armenians, Jews and Persians. Around the market stood *hans*, courtyard inns where caravans unloaded and craftsmen worked.

POWER AND POLITICS

This was the end of the overland routes: silk from Persia, furs from Russia, spices by way of Egypt. Ottoman control of those routes, and the tolls that came with it, was one reason Portugal and Spain went looking for a sea road to Asia.

The market's decline was just as political. A trade treaty with Britain in 1838 opened the empire to cheap machine-made cloth, and the guild economy that the bazaar housed could not compete. It became a place where imported goods were sold and, eventually, a place for visitors.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · Acts 16:14 · 17:17 · 18:3 · 19:24–27 · Revelation 2:18–29

The early church grew up among guilds like these. Paul's first convert in Europe was Lydia, "a seller of purple, of the city of Thyatira" (Acts 16:14), a town known from inscriptions for its dyers' guild. Paul worked at his own trade as a tentmaker (Acts 18:3) and reasoned "in the market daily" at Athens (17:17). At Ephesus a guild of silversmiths started the riot against him (19:24–27). Many scholars read the letter to Thyatira (Revelation 2:18–29) against the same background, since guild banquets meant eating meat offered to idols.

LOOK FOR

- The İç Bedesten, the fifteenth-century core, with a Byzantine eagle carved over its east gate
- Zincirli Han, the best preserved of the courtyard inns
- The number of the gate you came in by. There are more than twenty, and they look alike

09

Hodjapasha and the Whirling Dervishes

Hocapaşa Kültür Merkezi · the Mevlevi sema

DAY 3 · EVENING

A Sufi rite of remembrance, performed in a fifteenth-century bathhouse. It is both a religious ceremony and, because of twentieth-century politics, a staged one.

HISTORY

The hall is a fifteenth-century public bath, built by tradition for Hoca Sinan Pasha, a tutor and vizier of Mehmed II. It worked as a bath for some five hundred years before it was converted for performances.

The ceremony, the *sema*, belongs to the Mevlevi order, organised in Konya after the death of the poet and teacher Jalal al-Din Rumi in 1273 (section 16). It has a fixed sequence: a sung eulogy to the Prophet, a drumbeat, an improvisation on the reed flute, a slow procession three times round the floor, and then four passages of turning, each called a *selam*, closing with a recitation from the Qur'an.

Everything is symbolic. The tall felt hat stands for the tombstone of the ego, the white skirt for its shroud, the black cloak, dropped before turning, for the grave. The right palm is raised to receive and the left turned down to give. The dervish turns to his left, around the heart.

THE PEOPLE

The Mevlevis were the order of the Ottoman educated class. Sultans, poets, calligraphers and composers belonged to it, and much of Ottoman classical music was written in its lodges. Selim III, sultan from 1789, was a Mevlevi and composed for the ceremony. A dervish trained for 1,001 days, beginning in the lodge kitchen.

POWER AND POLITICS

In 1925 the Republic closed every dervish lodge in Turkey and banned the orders, which it saw as rivals to a secular state. That law has never been repealed. From 1953 the government allowed the *sema* to be performed in Konya as a cultural event, and UNESCO has listed it as intangible heritage since 2008. What you watch is therefore a real rite carried out by trained practitioners in a setting the law defines as a performance. The audience is asked to stay silent and not to applaud until the dervishes have left.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · compare Luke 7:11–17 · John 3:3 · John 9 · John 11 · Galatians 2:20

Rumi, whose followers perform the ceremony, refers to Jesus often. In his poetry Jesus is above all the one whose breath gives life, recalling the gospel accounts of the blind who received sight (John 9) and the dead who were raised (Luke 7:11–17; John 11). The Mevlevi way is a Muslim path, but its themes of dying to self and being born anew will sound familiar to readers of John 3:3 and of Paul's "I am crucified with Christ: nevertheless I live; yet not I, but Christ liveth in me" (Galatians 2:20).

10 Kariye

Kariye Camii · the Church of the Holy Saviour in Chora

DAY 4 · SUN 18 OCT

A small monastery church by the land walls holding the finest surviving Byzantine mosaics and frescoes, made in the empire's last century.

HISTORY

"Chora" means "in the country". The first monastery here lay outside Constantine's walls, and the name stuck after the walls of 413 enclosed it. The core of the present church was built about 1077–1081 by Maria Doukaina, mother-in-law of the emperor Alexios I, and remodelled a generation later.

Its fame rests on the decoration paid for between about 1315 and 1321 by Theodore Metochites and carried out by unnamed artists who were contemporaries of Giotto. The two entrance halls carry mosaic cycles of the life of the Virgin and of the infancy and miracles of Christ. The side chapel, built for burials, is frescoed with the Last Judgement and with the Anastasis: Christ in white, striding over the broken gates of hell and pulling Adam and Eve from their tombs.

The church became a mosque around 1500 and the images were covered. It was a museum from 1945, when an American team uncovered and conserved the decoration, until 2020. It reopened as a mosque in May 2024.

THE PEOPLE

Metochites was the emperor's chief minister, an astronomer and philosopher, and the richest man in the empire. Over the door to the nave he had himself shown kneeling before Christ, holding a model of the church and wearing an enormous striped hat. When his emperor was overthrown in 1328 his palace was sacked and he was exiled. He was allowed back to end his life as a monk in the monastery he had rebuilt, and died there in 1332.

POWER AND POLITICS

The art was made while the state was collapsing. By 1320 Byzantium had lost almost all of Anatolia to Turkish emirates, one of which, the Ottomans, took the city of Bursa in 1326. A mercenary army had ravaged its European provinces, its trade was in Venetian and Genoese hands, and the emperor was at war with his own grandson. Historians call the revival of these decades the Palaiologan Renaissance; it had no military or financial strength behind it.

The church stands a few hundred metres from the stretch of wall where the Ottoman assault broke through on 29 May 1453, and it was among the first buildings looted.

NEW TESTAMENT

Matthew 1–2 · 25:31–46 · Luke 1–3 · John 2:1–11 · 1 Peter 3:18–20 · 4:6 · compare Doctrine and Covenants 138

Kariye is a picture Bible. The domes of the inner hall set out the genealogies of Matthew 1 and Luke 3. The outer hall follows the infancy narratives: Joseph and Mary registering for the census ("there went out a decree from Caesar Augustus, that all the world should be taxed", Luke 2:1), the Nativity, the Magi and the massacre of the innocents (Matthew 2). Then come the miracles, beginning with the water made wine at Cana (John 2). The cycle of Mary's early life comes from the second-century *Protevangelium of James*, not from the New Testament.

The Anastasis fresco illustrates what 1 Peter describes: Christ, after his death, "went and preached unto the spirits in prison" (3:19), "for for this cause was the gospel preached also to them that are dead" (4:6). These are the chapters whose reading prompted Joseph F. Smith's 1918 vision recorded in Doctrine and Covenants 138, so Latter-day Saint visitors may find the painting especially striking. The Last Judgement beside it follows Matthew 25:31–46.

LOOK FOR

- Metochites and his hat, over the inner door
- The Anastasis in the apse of the side chapel
- The tender scenes from Mary's childhood, such as her first seven steps

PART II

DAYS 4–6

Cappadocia

A high volcanic plateau in the middle of Anatolia, soft enough to carve and for most of its history a frontier between rival empires.

II Cappadocia

Old Persian Katpatuka · Turkish Kapadokya

DAYS 4–6

Volcanoes laid the rock down, water cut it into cones and canyons, and people have been hollowing it out for three thousand years, usually because someone was invading.

HISTORY

Over millions of years the volcanoes Erciyes, Hasan and Göllü Dağ buried the plateau in ash, which hardened into tuff, a stone soft enough to cut with hand tools. Where a cap of harder rock protected the tuff beneath, erosion left the pillars called fairy chimneys. Tuff firms up on contact with air, so a carved room lasts.

Around 1950 BC Assyrian merchants set up a trading colony at Kanesh, near modern Kayseri, and their clay tablets are the oldest writing found in Anatolia. The Hittites ruled the region from about 1650 to 1180 BC. In the sixth century BC it became a Persian province, Katpatuka, known for its horses and paying part of its tribute in them. After Alexander, native kings, the first of them of Persian descent, ruled an independent Cappadocia for three centuries, until the emperor Tiberius annexed it in AD 17.

Christianity came early. In the fourth century three Cappadocians, Basil of Caesarea, his brother Gregory of Nyssa and their friend Gregory of Nazianzus, shaped the doctrine of the Trinity as most churches still confess it, and Basil wrote the rule that eastern monks still follow.

From the seventh century to the tenth this was the frontier with the Arab caliphate, raided almost every year. The population dug in, and the underground cities were enlarged. A Byzantine recovery after about 950 brought a century of peace and the painted churches of Göreme. The Seljuk Turks took the region after 1071, and it was a quiet Ottoman backwater from the fifteenth century. UNESCO listed it in 1985.

THE PEOPLE

The rural population kept its own Cappadocian language into late antiquity and was a byword among sophisticated Greeks for rustic manners. Persian settlers and their fire-priests were still here in the first century AD, as the geographer Strabo noted. Armenians moved in during the eleventh century, and Turkish nomads and farmers after them.

The Christians stayed. By Ottoman times many spoke Turkish as their mother tongue and wrote it in Greek letters. In 1923–24 they were deported to Greece under the population exchange agreed at Lausanne, and Muslims from Greece were settled in their villages. The stone mansions and locked churches you pass in the towns are theirs.

POWER AND POLITICS

Cappadocia has almost always been a borderland: between Lydia and the Medes, between Rome and Persia, between Byzantium and the caliphate, between Byzantium and the Seljuks. Rome stationed two legions along its eastern edge, on the Euphrates. The Byzantines defended it differently, as the next section explains.

NEW TESTAMENT

Acts 2:9 · 1 Peter 1:1 · compare Doctrine and Covenants 138:5

Cappadocians are listed among the pilgrims in Jerusalem who heard the apostles at Pentecost, each "in our own tongue, wherein we were born" (Acts 2:8–9), and some of them presumably carried the message home. A generation later Peter's first letter was addressed "to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia" (1 Peter 1:1). Doctrine and Covenants 138:5 recalls those "primitive saints". The letter's themes of suffering and of Christ's ministry to the dead (3:18–20; 4:6) link this region to the Anastasis at Kariye.

12 Derinkuyu Underground City

"Deep Well" · Greek Malakopea

DAY 5 · MON 19 OCT

A refuge for a whole district, cut downward through the rock to a depth of about eighty-five metres, with stables, kitchens, wells and doors that could be shut only from inside.

HISTORY

Carved rock cannot be dated directly, so the beginnings are uncertain. The first cellars may be Phrygian work of the eighth or seventh century BC. The great expansion came in the Byzantine centuries, above all during the wars with the Arabs from the 600s to the 900s. The city was used again when Mongol armies came through in the fourteenth century, and the habit never quite died. A British linguist who worked in the district just before the First World War recorded that when news came of massacres at Adana in 1909, the Greeks of one nearby village went underground for several nights.

The tunnels were abandoned after 1923 and forgotten. In 1963 a householder knocked through a cellar wall and found a passage. The site opened to visitors in 1969. Eight levels can be visited of as many as eighteen. Estimates that twenty thousand people sheltered here are an upper limit, and more cautious figures are a fraction of that.

THE PEOPLE

The users were farmers and their animals. Nobody lived here permanently; families came down with their livestock and stores for days or weeks while raiders passed overhead. The upper levels held stables, wine and oil presses and communal kitchens. Lower down are storerooms, a chapel cut in the shape of a cross and a long vaulted room often described as a school. More than fifty shafts brought in air. The wells did not open at the surface, so they could not be poisoned from above.

POWER AND POLITICS

Arab raids were seasonal expeditions that came through the passes of the Taurus mountains after the harvest, aiming at plunder and captives more than conquest. Byzantium could not garrison the whole frontier. A military handbook of the tenth century sets out the policy instead: evacuate the people and animals to strongholds, shadow the raiders, and attack them on the way home when they are slowed by loot. The underground cities are that policy cut into rock.

WORTH KNOWING

Guides often say that Christians hid here from Roman soldiers. Cappadocia did have martyrs under the pagan emperors, but persecution was sporadic, and archaeologists attribute the large-scale digging to the Byzantine period, when the people hiding were Christian subjects of a Christian empire and the danger was foreign raiders.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · Hebrews 11:38 · 1 Peter 4:12

The tunnels were mostly cut centuries after the New Testament, but the Christians who sheltered here knew the words of Hebrews about the faithful who “wandered in deserts, and in mountains, and in dens and caves of the earth” (11:38). They also knew Peter’s letter to this very region: “think it not strange concerning the fiery trial which is to try you” (1 Peter 4:12). The cross-shaped chapel on a lower level shows that worship went on underground.

LOOK FOR

- The rolling stone doors, a metre across and weighing up to half a tonne, each with a socket for a lever on the inner side only
- Soot on the kitchen ceilings and tether holes in the stables
- The start of a tunnel said to run toward the neighbouring city of Kaymaklı, nine kilometres north

13

Avanos

Ancient Venessa, on the Red River

DAY 5 · MON 19 OCT

A potters' town on the longest river in Turkey, using clay from the same banks since the Bronze Age.

HISTORY

The Kızılırmak, the Red River, runs 1,355 kilometres in a great bend through central Anatolia and takes its colour from iron-rich silt. That clay has been thrown on wheels at Avanos since Hittite times. The town is usually identified with ancient Venessa, where Strabo describes a temple of Zeus that owned the surrounding land and some three thousand temple servants, and whose priest ranked among the great men of the Cappadocian kingdom.

Under the Seljuks the town lay on the caravan road between Konya and Kayseri. The thirteenth-century caravanserai of Sarıhan stands a few kilometres to the east.

THE PEOPLE

Pottery is a family trade here, taught by fathers to sons on a wheel turned by foot. Local lore says a young man could not marry until he could throw a lidded jar. The women of the town wove carpets. Greek and Armenian families lived here until the 1920s. The workshops you visit are cut into the tuff, which keeps the clay cool and damp.

POWER AND POLITICS

The Greeks called this river the Halys, and for a time it was the most famous border in the world. After an eclipse stopped a battle in 585 BC, the Lydians and the Medes agreed that it would divide their empires. In 547 BC Croesus of Lydia asked the oracle at Delphi whether to attack Persia and was told that if he crossed the river he would destroy a great empire. He crossed, and the empire he destroyed was his own. Cyrus the Great then took all of Anatolia.

The Seljuk caravanserais belong to a different kind of statecraft. The sultans built them a day's march apart, gave travellers three days' free lodging and compensated merchants for losses to bandits, which drew the trade between Persia and the Mediterranean through their lands.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · Romans 9:20–21 · 2 Corinthians 4:7 · 2 Timothy 2:20 · Revelation 2:27

Watching a potter at the wheel is the best commentary on some of Paul's images. "Hath not the potter power over the clay, of the same lump to make one vessel unto honour, and another unto dishonour?" (Romans 9:21), echoing Jeremiah 18. "We have this treasure in earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us" (2 Corinthians 4:7): the cheap clay pots of daily life, not silver. Revelation 2:27 pictures nations broken "as the vessels of a potter".

14

Göreme Open-Air Museum

Ancient Korama · a Byzantine monastic valley

DAY 5 · MON 19 OCT

A cluster of monasteries carved into one small valley, with churches painted during Byzantium's last great century.

HISTORY

Monks settled this valley because Basil of Caesarea, bishop of the nearby capital until 379, taught that they should live in small working communities and not as solitary hermits. Most of what you see dates from the tenth to the twelfth century, the peaceful period after the Byzantine armies pushed the frontier far to the east.

The churches imitate built architecture. They have columns, arches and domes that hold nothing up, because the masons cut them out of solid rock. The simplest are decorated in red ochre straight onto the stone, with crosses and geometric patterns. The richer ones were plastered and painted with full cycles of the life of Christ by artists who knew the style of Constantinople.

The Tokalı Church, just below the main gate, is the largest and has tenth-century paintings on a deep blue ground. The Dark Church, of the eleventh century, has one small window; the lack of light preserved its colours almost intact. Others are named for details: the Apple, the Sandal, the Snake.

THE PEOPLE

The monks and nuns ate together at long tables and benches cut from the rock, which you can still see in the refectories. Their patrons were the military landowners of Cappadocia, families such as the Phokas clan, which put one of its sons on the imperial throne in 963. Donors appear in some of the paintings as small figures at the feet of the saints.

Christian life continued under the Turks. A church in the Ihlara valley, painted in the 1280s, carries an inscription honouring both the Seljuk sultan and the Byzantine emperor. The scratched-out faces are mostly the work of later villagers, who feared the power of painted eyes, and of visitors with penknives.

POWER AND POLITICS

Between about 950 and 1050 Byzantium was the strongest state in the Christian world. It recovered Crete, Cilicia and Antioch, and the generals who did it were Anatolian magnates whose wealth and private armies increasingly rivalled the emperor's. The churches of Göreme are monuments of that class. Its quarrels with the court in Constantinople weakened the army in the decades before the Seljuk victory at Manzikert in 1071, which opened Anatolia to the Turks.

NEW TESTAMENT

Gospel scenes from Matthew, Luke and John · Acts 1:9–11 · 2:44–45 · 4:32

The painted churches are gospel narratives on rock. Across the churches look for the Nativity, the Baptism (Matthew 3:13–17), the raising of Lazarus (John 11), the entry into Jerusalem, the Last Supper, the betrayal, the Crucifixion and the Ascension (Acts 1:9–11).

The monasteries themselves were an attempt to live out Acts. Basil of Caesarea, whose rule the monks followed, held up the Jerusalem church, where "all that believed were together, and had all things common" (Acts 2:44), as the model for shared work, prayer and property.

LOOK FOR

- In the Dark Church, the Nativity, the Betrayal and Christ enthroned in the dome
- In the Snake Church, St George and St Theodore spearing the dragon, and the hermit Onuphrius
- The red-ochre crosses and patterns in the Chapel of St Barbara
- Rock-cut tables and wine presses in the monastery refectories

15

Uçhisar Castle

Uçhisar Kalesi, "the outer fortress"

DAY 5 · MON 19 OCT

A natural tower of tuff sixty metres high, tunnelled into a citadel. It is the highest point in the Göreme valleys. From the top the whole region is visible, as far as the volcano Erciyes on a clear day.

HISTORY

Nobody built Uçhisar; it was dug. Rooms, stairs, cisterns and store pits were cut into the rock over many centuries, and a tunnel ran down to the stream bed so that the garrison could reach water under siege. The Byzantines used it as a lookout in a chain with the similar rocks at Ortahisar and Ürgüp. The name first appears in writing in the fourteenth century, when the Seljuks' successors held it. People lived in the rock and around its base until the mid-twentieth century, when collapses made it unsafe.

THE PEOPLE

The villagers were farmers and vine-growers. The small square holes that pattern the cliffs of the valley below are dovecotes. Pigeon droppings were the fertiliser for the thin volcanic soil, and families counted their birds as part of their wealth. Wine has been made here since Hittite times, and the Christian villages kept the trade going through the Ottoman period.

POWER AND POLITICS

The rock served every frontier in turn. Byzantine watchmen looked out for Arab raiders, then for Turks. After the Seljuk state broke up, the Karamanid emirs held central Anatolia and contested it with the rising Ottomans for a century and a half, until the Ottomans annexed the region in the later fifteenth century and the castle lost its purpose.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · John 2:1–11 · 15:1–5 · Luke 2:24 · Matthew 3:16

The valley below shows two everyday things the gospels take for granted. Vineyards: "I am the vine, ye are the branches" (John 15:5), and the first miracle

at a wedding in Cana (John 2). And pigeons: the dovecotes in these cliffs raised birds like the “pair of turtledoves, or two young pigeons” that Mary and Joseph offered at the Temple (Luke 2:24), the offering the law allowed a family too poor for a lamb. The dove is also the sign of the Spirit at Jesus’ baptism (Matthew 3:16).

PART III

DAY 6

Konya

The Iconium of Paul and Barnabas, the capital of the Seljuk Turks, and the city where Rumi lived, wrote and is buried.

16

Konya and the Mevlana Museum

Ancient Iconium · Mevlâna Müzesi, the lodge and tomb of Rumi

DAY 6 · TUE 20 OCT

The itinerary's "Home of the Whirling Dervishes" is the lodge built around the tomb of Rumi, in a city that was the capital of the Seljuk Turks.

HISTORY

The Konya plain is one of the oldest farmed landscapes on earth. At Çatalhöyük, forty kilometres to the south-east, several thousand people lived in a town of mud-brick houses entered through the roof between about 7400 and 6000 BC. Iconium itself was Hittite, then Phrygian, Persian and Greek, and came under Rome in 25 BC as a city of the province of Galatia.

For the Byzantines it was a frontier town, raided by the Arabs. After the Seljuk victory at Manzikert in 1071 it changed hands for good, and from about 1100 it was the capital of the Seljuk Sultanate of Rum. Its best years came under Alaeddin Keykubad I (1220–1237), who walled the city, built the mosque that still stands on the citadel mound, and offered refuge to scholars fleeing the Mongol conquests in the east. In 1243 the Mongols arrived anyway and defeated the Seljuk army at Köse Dağ. The sultans ruled on as Mongol vassals until about 1308. The Karamanid emirs followed, and the Ottomans took the city in the 1460s.

RUMI AND HIS ORDER

Jalal al-Din Muhammad was born in 1207 in the region of Balkh, in what is now Afghanistan and Tajikistan. His father, a preacher and jurist, took the family west ahead of the Mongols, and around 1228 the sultan invited them to Konya. The son succeeded his father as a teacher of law and theology. Turks call him Mevlana, "our master"; "Rumi" simply means "of Rum", the man from Roman Anatolia.

In 1244 he met a wandering dervish, Shams of Tabriz, and the encounter turned a respected scholar into a mystic and a poet. After Shams disappeared, Rumi composed the *Masnavi*, some 25,000 rhyming couplets of stories and teaching, and thousands of lyric poems, almost all in Persian. He died on 17 December 1273. His followers call that night his wedding, the soul's union with God, and by their account Christians and Jews walked in his funeral procession with the Muslims.

His son organised the disciples into the Mevlevi order. A mausoleum was raised over the grave in 1274. The fluted, turquoise-tiled tower above it, now Konya's emblem, was added by the Karamanids in the 1390s, and the lodge grew around it under Ottoman patronage. It was closed with all the others in 1925 and reopened as a museum two years later. Most of its many visitors come as pilgrims.

THE PEOPLE

Seljuk Konya was a mixed city. The court and the learned wrote Persian, the soldiers and the nomads on the plateau spoke Turkish, and many of the townspeople and farmers were Greek- and Armenian-speaking Christians. Sultans married Byzantine and Georgian princesses, and Greek masons worked on their mosques. Rumi's poetry includes lines in Greek and Turkish alongside the Persian.

POWER AND POLITICS

The Seljuks called their state the Sultanate of Rome because they ruled land that the Muslim world had always known as Roman. They held it against Byzantium to the west, which they defeated decisively at Myriokephalon in 1176, against the Crusaders, whose armies crossed their territory three times (Frederick Barbarossa stormed Konya itself in 1190), and against Armenian and Turkish neighbours to the south and east.

Their wealth came from trade. They signed commercial treaties with Venice and built the chain of fortified caravanserais that you pass on the road from Cappadocia. The Mongol defeat of 1243 ended their independence, and Rumi wrote his poetry under a Mongol protectorate in a city full of refugees.

NEW TESTAMENT

Acts 13:51–14:6 · 14:21–23 · 16:1–5 · 2 Timothy 3:11 · Galatians 4:13

Paul and Barnabas preached in the synagogue at Iconium on the first missionary journey, and "a great multitude both of the Jews and also of the Greeks believed" (Acts 14:1). Opponents plotted to stone them, and they fled to Lystra and Derbe (14:5–6). At Lystra, a mound about 35 kilometres to the south-west, Paul was first hailed as a god and then stoned and left for dead (14:8–19). The two returned through Iconium to appoint elders (14:21–23).

Timothy came from this district and was "well reported of by the brethren that were at Lystra and Iconium" (Acts 16:2). Years later Paul reminded him of the "persecutions, afflictions, which came unto me at Antioch, at Iconium, at Lystra" (2 Timothy 3:11). Iconium lay in the Roman province of Galatia, and many scholars think Galatians was written to these churches; if so, "ye know how through infirmity of the flesh I preached the gospel unto you at the first" (4:13) describes Paul's arrival here. Paul's Iconium lies under the citadel mound and the modern streets, so none of it is visible.

KEY DATES

c. 7400 BC	Çatalhöyük settled
c. AD 47	Paul and Barnabas at Iconium
1071	Manzikert; the Seljuks enter Anatolia
1220–37	Reign of Alaeddin Keykubad I
1243	Mongol victory at Köse Dağ
1273	Death of Rumi

LOOK FOR

- ◇ Rumi's tomb under the green dome, covered in gold-embroidered cloth, with his father's beside it
- ◇ The hall where the *sema* was performed, now displaying instruments and robes
- ◇ Early manuscripts of the *Masnavi*
- ◇ The dervishes' cells around the courtyard, furnished as they were
- ◇ On the drive: Sultanhanı, the largest Seljuk caravanserai (1229), on the Aksaray–Konya road

PART IV

DAYS 6–7

The Lycus Valley

Hierapolis and Laodicea face each other across ten kilometres of valley floor. Paul's letter to the Colossians names them together.

17

Hierapolis and Pamukkale

"The Holy City" and "the Cotton Castle"

DAY 7 · WED 21 OCT

A Greek and Roman spa city on top of a white cliff of its own making. People came for the hot springs to be cured, and many stayed in one of the largest cemeteries of the ancient world.

HISTORY

The springs rise warm and saturated with dissolved limestone. As the water runs over the edge of the plateau it cools, gives off carbon dioxide and deposits the mineral as travertine. Over thousands of years this has built a white terrace nearly three kilometres long and 160 metres high: Pamukkale, the Cotton Castle.

The spot was sacred long before there was a city. A cave here gave off a gas that killed animals, and the Phrygians took it for an entrance to the underworld and a seat of the mother goddess Cybele. The city of Hierapolis was laid out in the early second century BC under the kings of Pergamon, who had just been awarded the region by Rome. In 133 BC the last of those kings left his whole kingdom to Rome in his will.

Earthquakes flattened the city in AD 17 and again in AD 60. Nearly everything standing was built afterwards, in the prosperous second and third centuries: the main street and its triple gate, the baths, and a theatre for some twelve thousand with its carved stage building largely intact. The emperor Hadrian visited in 129.

Christian Hierapolis grew up around the memory of Philip. An eight-sided shrine was built on the hill above the city in the early fifth century. More earthquakes and the Persian wars of the seventh century emptied the town. A small Seljuk fort stood here in the Middle Ages, and after an earthquake in 1354 the site was abandoned. UNESCO listed it in 1988.

THE PEOPLE

The city's business was wool and health. Its mineral water fixed dyes, and inscriptions name guilds of dyers, wool-washers and carpet-weavers. Its cemetery holds more than twelve hundred tombs of every type, from house-shaped vaults to simple sarcophagi, the graves of people from all over Asia Minor. One merchant, Flavius Zeuxis, recorded on his tomb that he had sailed around the southern cape of Greece to Italy seventy-two times.

There was a large Jewish community. One tomb inscription leaves money to two of the city's trade guilds for annual commemorations at Passover and at Pentecost. The Stoic philosopher Epictetus was born here as a slave about AD 50. Papias, bishop in the early second century, collected sayings handed down from those who had known the apostles; the fragments that survive are the earliest statements we have on who wrote the gospels of Mark and Matthew.

POWER AND POLITICS

The valley changed hands with the fortunes of Alexander's successors. The Seleucid kings of Syria held it until Rome defeated them in 190 BC and gave the region to its ally Pergamon. The founding of Hierapolis, across the valley from Seleucid Laodicea, was a way of marking that transfer. Under Rome the city's fortunes depended on the emperor's favour: tax relief after the earthquakes, and later the coveted right to build a temple for the imperial cult.

PHILIP AND HIS TOMB

A bishop of Ephesus writing about AD 190 says that Philip, "one of the twelve apostles", was buried at Hierapolis with his daughters. Acts 21:8–9 gives four prophesying daughters to a different Philip, the evangelist, and already in antiquity the two were being confused, so scholars disagree about which one lived here. In 2011 the Italian excavator Francesco D'Andria found a first-century tomb enclosed in a church about forty metres from the octagonal shrine, and identified it as the grave the pilgrims came to venerate. It is empty; the relics are thought to have been taken to Constantinople in the sixth century and later to Rome.

NEW TESTAMENT

Colossians 1:7 · 2:1 · 4:13 · Philip: John 1:43–46 · 6:5–7 · 12:20–22 · 14:8–9 · Acts 6:5 · Acts 8 · Acts 21:8–9

Paul names Hierapolis once, with its neighbours: Epaphras "hath a great zeal for you, and them that are in Laodicea, and them in Hierapolis" (Colossians 4:13). Paul probably never came here himself. The churches of the valley were planted by Epaphras during Paul's years at Ephesus, among people who had "not seen my face in the flesh" (Colossians 1:7; 2:1).

Which Philip lies here? Philip the apostle appears in John's gospel: he brings Nathanael to Jesus (1:43–46), is asked where bread can be bought for the five thousand (6:5–7), brings the Greeks who said "Sir, we would see Jesus" (12:21), and asks, "Lord, shew us the Father" (14:8). Philip the evangelist was one of the seven chosen in Acts 6:5. He preached in Samaria, baptised the Ethiopian official (Acts 8) and lived at Caesarea with "four daughters, virgins, which did prophesy" (21:9). Read both sets of passages before the visit.

KEY DATES

c. 190 BC	City founded under Pergamon
133 BC	Bequeathed to Rome
AD 60	Earthquake; the city is rebuilt
c. 400–450	Shrine of Philip built
1354	Final abandonment
2011	Tomb identified

LOOK FOR

- ◇ The Plutonium, the "gate of hell", located in 2013 near the Temple of Apollo. Priests once led animals in to die and walked out unharmed
- ◇ The theatre's stage reliefs of Apollo, Artemis and Dionysus
- ◇ In the museum, housed in the vaulted Roman baths, sarcophagi and sculpture from Hierapolis and Laodicea
- ◇ The Antique Pool, where you can swim over fallen columns (separate fee)

18

Laodicea

Laodikeia on the Lycus · the last of the Seven Churches

DAY 7 · WED 21 OCT

A banking and textile city at a crossroads, rich enough to refuse Rome's help, and the target of the sharpest of the seven letters in Revelation.

HISTORY

The Seleucid king Antiochus II refounded an older village here between 261 and 253 BC and named it for his wife, Laodice. It passed to Pergamon in 188 BC and to Rome in 133 BC. It stood where the highway from Ephesus to the Euphrates crossed the road from the north to the Mediterranean ports, and it became the financial centre of the interior. Cicero, as governor of Cilicia in 50 BC, held his court here and cashed his letters of credit at its banks.

Three things made the city's name. It produced a soft, glossy black wool and the garments woven from it. It was a banking centre. And it had a medical school whose eye ointment was sold across the empire. When the earthquake of AD 60 destroyed the city, the historian Tacitus recorded that Laodicea rebuilt from its own resources, without the imperial aid other cities asked for.

The city became an important bishopric and hosted a church council in the 360s. An earthquake early in the seventh century ended it, and the survivors moved to the site of modern Denizli. Turkish archaeologists have worked here continuously since 2003, re-erecting colonnades street by street. Their most important find, located by ground radar in 2010, is a large church of the early fourth century with its baptistery, among the oldest church buildings known anywhere.

THE PEOPLE

The first citizens were Greek and Macedonian settlers planted by the Seleucids among the native Phrygians. Jews arrived early: about 210 BC Antiochus III moved two thousand Jewish families from Mesopotamia into this part of Anatolia to secure it. In 62 BC a Roman governor confiscated twenty pounds of gold that the Jews of the Laodicea district had collected for the Temple in Jerusalem, a sum that implies a community of several thousand men.

The church was probably founded by Epaphras of Colossae, a colleague of Paul, and met in private houses; Paul sends greetings to "Nymphas, and the church which is in his house". One column found on the site carries a menorah with a cross cut above it.

POWER AND POLITICS

Laodicea was founded as a Seleucid strongpoint on the road west, and it repeatedly had to choose sides. It was besieged by Mithridates of Pontus in 88 BC and held out against a Parthian-backed invasion in 40 BC. The citizen who led the second resistance was rewarded when Mark Antony made his son a king. Rome granted the city the status of a free city, and its mint, its assize court and its imperial temple made it the capital of its district. The pride that Revelation attacks had a real basis.

NEW TESTAMENT

Colossians 2:1 · 4:13–16 · Revelation 1:11 · 3:14–22

Revelation 3:14–22 turns the city's boasts against it. The church says, "I am rich, and increased with goods, and have need of nothing." It is told to buy gold tried in the fire, as an answer to the banks; white raiment, as an answer to the black wool; and eyesalve, "that thou mayest see".

The most famous image has a local explanation too. Hierapolis, in plain view across the valley, had hot water that healed. Colossae, up the valley, had cold water from mountain springs. Laodicea had neither. Its supply came several kilometres by aqueduct and arrived tepid and heavy with minerals. "So then because thou art lukewarm, and neither cold nor hot, I will spue thee out of my mouth." On this reading the charge is that the church is of no use to anyone, where hot or cold water would each have done some good. The letter ends with an invitation, not a sentence: "Behold, I stand at the door, and knock" (3:20).

Paul asks that his letters to Colossae and Laodicea be exchanged and read in both churches (Colossians 4:16), and greets "Nymphas, and the church which is in his house" (4:15). The letter to Laodicea has not survived under that name.

KEY DATES

c. 255 BC	Founded by Antiochus II
50 BC	Cicero holds court here
AD 60	Earthquake; rebuilt unaided
c. 363	Council of Laodicea
c. 610	Destroyed and abandoned
2010	Fourth-century church found

LOOK FOR

- ◇ The water tower and the stone pipes of the aqueduct, almost closed by lime deposits
- ◇ The church, under a modern roof, with its mosaic floors and cross-shaped baptismal pool
- ◇ Syria Street, the colonnaded main road, and Temple A, where a glass floor shows the vaults below
- ◇ The white terraces of Pamukkale across the valley to the north

PART V

DAYS 7–9

Ephesus and the Aegean

Greek Ionia: the coast where Anatolia met the Mediterranean, and the Roman province of Asia's first city.

19 Kuşadası

"Bird Island" · Italian Scala Nova

DAYS 7–9 · OVERNIGHT BASE

The port that replaced Ephesus when the river filled its harbour with silt. Your base for two nights.

HISTORY

A small Greek town stood here in antiquity, overshadowed by Ephesus twenty kilometres to the north. As the harbour of Ephesus became unusable in the Middle Ages, shipping moved here. Venetian and Genoese merchants called the place Scala Nova, the new landing. Turkish emirs held it from the early 1300s and the Ottomans took it in 1413. The town is named for the islet in the bay, Güvercinada or Pigeon Island, now joined to the shore by a causeway and crowned with a small fort. The stone caravanserai by the harbour was built in 1618 for a grand vizier.

THE PEOPLE

Until 1922 much of the population was Greek, as it was along this whole coast, with Jewish and Armenian merchants in the bazaar. They left in the war and population exchange of 1922–24, and Muslim refugees from Crete and the Balkans took their place. Mass tourism and cruise ships arrived in the 1970s and turned a fishing town into a city.

POWER AND POLITICS

The Greek island of Samos lies less than two kilometres off the peninsula south of town. That strait has been a front line more than once. In 479 BC the Greek fleet destroyed the Persian navy at Mycale, on the mainland shore facing Samos, by tradition on the same day as the land victory at Plataea that the Serpent Column in Istanbul commemorates. The walls on Pigeon Island were strengthened in the 1820s, when the Greek War of Independence brought raiders across from the islands. Samos has been part of Greece since 1912, and the sea border still runs down the middle of the channel.

> **NEW TESTAMENT**
> Acts 20:13–17 · Revelation 1:9
>
> Paul sailed past this coast at the end of his third journey, hurrying to reach Jerusalem by Pentecost: "the next day we arrived at Samos, and tarried at Trogyllium; and the next day we came to Miletus" (Acts 20:15). Trogyllium is the

tip of the peninsula just south of town, facing Samos across the strait. Rather than lose time going up to Ephesus, he sent for the Ephesian elders to meet him at Miletus, about 50 kilometres south, for the farewell of Acts 20:17–38. The island of Patmos, where John "was in the isle that is called Patmos, for the word of God" (Revelation 1:9), lies beyond Samos, less than a hundred kilometres to the south-west.

20 The Temple of Artemis

The Artemision · one of the Seven Wonders

DAY 8 · THU 22 OCT

One rebuilt column in a marshy field marks the largest temple of the Greek world. The city of Ephesus existed because of this sanctuary.

HISTORY

There was a shrine here in the Bronze Age, to an Anatolian mother goddess whom the Greek settlers identified with their Artemis. The Artemis of Ephesus was never the Greek huntress, though. Her statues show a stiff standing figure, her chest covered with rounded forms that have been read as breasts, eggs or offerings.

About 560 BC the Ephesians began a temple entirely of marble on a scale no Greek city had attempted. Croesus of Lydia, who had just conquered them, paid for many of its columns, and fragments bearing his name are in the British Museum. In 356 BC a man named Herostratus burned it down so that his name would be remembered. Tradition put the fire on the night Alexander the Great was born.

The Ephesians rebuilt it larger still: according to the Roman writer Pliny, 127 columns each about eighteen metres high, on a platform well over a hundred metres long. That is the temple the ancient lists called a Wonder. Goths plundered it in AD 262, Christian emperors closed it in the late fourth century, and its marble went into the Basilica of St John and other buildings. The site was lost under six metres of river silt until the English engineer John Turtle Wood found it in 1869 after six years of searching.

THE PEOPLE

The temple employed eunuch priests, priestesses, musicians, guards and administrators. It drew pilgrims from the whole Mediterranean, above all for the spring festival, and they supported a trade in souvenirs. The silversmiths who rioted against Paul made their living selling small shrines of the goddess to these visitors.

POWER AND POLITICS

The sanctuary was a power in its own right. It owned estates, quarries and fisheries. It offered asylum, and fugitives who reached its boundary could not be seized. Because no one would dare rob it, it served as the safest deposit bank in Asia, holding the funds of cities and kings. Every conqueror found it wiser to honour the temple than to offend it: Croesus paid for its columns, the Persians

spared it, and Alexander offered to finance the rebuilding. The Ephesians turned him down, tactfully, saying that it was not fitting for one god to build a temple to another.

FROM THE OVERLOOK

One view takes in four ages of the city. In front is the temple's single column, usually with a stork's nest on top. Behind it is the İsa Bey Mosque of 1375, then the Basilica of St John on the hill, and above them all the Byzantine and Turkish citadel.

NEW TESTAMENT

Acts 19:23–41 · compare Acts 17:24

This is the temple at the centre of the riot in Acts 19. Demetrius warned his fellow silversmiths that Paul's preaching meant "that the temple of the great goddess Diana should be despised, and her magnificence should be destroyed, whom all Asia and the world worshippeth" (19:27). Diana is the King James translators' Latin name for Artemis.

The town clerk calmed the crowd by reminding them that the city was "a worshipper of the great goddess Diana, and of the image which fell down from Jupiter" (19:35). The Greek word behind "worshipper", *neokoros*, is the official title Ephesus claimed as keeper of the temple. Paul had told the Athenians that God "dwelleth not in temples made with hands" (Acts 17:24); in the shadow of this one, the words had an edge.

21

Ephesus

Greek Ephesos · Turkish Efes

DAY 8 · THU 22 OCT

The capital of Roman Asia and one of the largest cities of the empire, where Paul worked longer than anywhere else. It is the best-preserved classical city in the eastern Mediterranean, largely because its harbour died and nobody built over it.

HISTORY

Hittite records of the fourteenth century BC mention Apasa, capital of the kingdom of Arzawa, which was very probably here. Greeks from across the Aegean settled around 1000 BC; legend named their leader as Androklos, an Athenian prince. The city fell to Croesus of Lydia about 560 BC and to Cyrus of Persia in 547. It joined the Ionian Revolt against Persia in 499, paid tribute to Athens in the fifth century, and was back under Persia from 387 until Alexander arrived in 334 BC.

The city has moved more than once, following the retreating coastline. About 290 BC Alexander's general Lysimachus forced the population onto the present site, between two hills, and gave it nine kilometres of walls. Rome inherited it with the rest of the kingdom of Pergamon in 133 BC.

In 88 BC the Ephesians sided with Mithridates of Pontus and joined in the massacre of the Italians living in Asia, tens of thousands in a single day by ancient accounts. Rome's revenge was financial and severe. A generation later Augustus made Ephesus the seat of the governor of Asia, and for the next two centuries it boomed. Almost everything on the main route dates from then.

The decline was slow. Goths raided in 262 and earthquakes followed. Under the Christian emperors the city hosted the church council of 431. The river Cayster went on silting up the harbour despite repeated dredging, and the sea is now six kilometres away. By the seventh century, with Arab fleets raiding the coast, most people had moved to the hill by the Basilica of St John. Austrian archaeologists have dug here since 1895. UNESCO listed the site in 2015.

THE PEOPLE

The citizens were Ionian Greeks, long mixed with the older peoples of the coast. Roman rule added Italian businessmen, imperial officials and freed slaves who had done well: the gate beside the library was put up by two freedmen of Augustus. There were Egyptians, with a temple to their gods, and a Jewish community whose rights Roman officials confirmed several times. A large share of the inhabitants were slaves.

The Terrace Houses show how the richest lived: seven residences stepping up the hill with marble-lined halls, wall paintings of philosophers and Muses, mosaic floors, running water and underfloor heating. One owner was a priest of Dionysus who built himself a private basilica. The plaster also carries the residents' scribbles, including shopping lists, sums, gladiators and love notes. An earthquake in the third century buried the houses, which is why they survive.

POWER AND POLITICS

Asia was the richest province Rome possessed, and Ephesus was where its taxes were counted and its governor landed. The city styled itself "first and greatest metropolis of Asia" and competed fiercely with Smyrna and Pergamon for titles and for the right to build temples to the emperors. Loyalty to Rome was displayed on every street, and it was profitable.

Everything depended on the harbour. Emperors paid to dredge it; Hadrian had the river diverted. When it finally failed, the trade went to Smyrna and Scala Nova, and the city's political weight went with it.

WORTH KNOWING

The figure of 250,000 inhabitants comes from older scholarship. Recent estimates based on the built-up area are lower, some well under 100,000. Either way Ephesus ranked with Alexandria and Antioch among the great cities of the Roman East. Only part of it, perhaps a fifth at most, has been excavated.

NEW TESTAMENT

Acts 18:19–28 · Acts 19 · Acts 20:17–38 · 1 Corinthians 15:32 · 16:8–9 · Ephesians · 1 Timothy 1:3 · Revelation 1:11 · 2:1–7

Paul stopped briefly on his second journey, leaving Priscilla and Aquila (Acts 18:19–21), who went on to teach Apollos here (18:24–28). He returned for about three years, around AD 52–55. He taught for three months in the synagogue and then daily in the lecture hall of Tyrannus (19:8–10), and wrote 1 Corinthians here: "a great door and effectual is opened unto me, and there are many adversaries" (1 Corinthians 16:9). Converts burned books of magic worth "fifty thousand pieces of silver" (Acts 19:19). His preaching cut into the trade in silver shrines, and the silversmiths' crowd filled the theatre and shouted for two hours, "Great is Diana of the Ephesians", until the town clerk talked them down (19:23–41). Stand in the theatre and read the chapter. Paul's farewell to the Ephesian elders is in Acts 20:17–38.

The letter to the Ephesians, with its image of the armour of God drawn from the Roman soldier (6:11–17), was probably meant to circulate among the churches of the province. Timothy was left in charge here (1 Timothy 1:3). Ephesus is the first of the seven churches of Revelation, praised for its endurance and told, "thou hast left thy first love" (2:4).

Early tradition places John here in old age, with Mary in his care (see the next section). In 431 the Council of Ephesus met in the Church of Mary, near the harbour, and affirmed her title "Mother of God".

KEY DATES

c. 1000 BC	Greek settlement
c. 290 BC	City moved to this site
133 BC	Passes to Rome
c. AD 52–55	Paul's long stay
c. 110–135	Library of Celsus built
262	Gothic raid
431	Council of Ephesus

LOOK FOR, WALKING DOWNHILL

- ◇ Curetes Street, with the Temple of Hadrian (about AD 118) and the public latrines
- ◇ The Terrace Houses, under their protective roof, opposite the temple
- ◇ The Library of Celsus, built as the tomb of a Greek from Sardis who became a Roman consul. It held some twelve thousand scrolls, and its façade was re-erected in the 1970s
- ◇ Marble Street, leading to the Great Theatre of about 24,000 seats, the scene of the riot
- ◇ Harbour Street, running straight from the theatre to a harbour that is now a reed bed

22

The Basilica of St John

Ayasuluk Hill, Selçuk

DAY 8 · THU 22 OCT

Justinian's great church over the grave venerated since the second century as that of John, on the hill where Ephesus began and ended.

HISTORY

Ayasuluk Hill is the oldest part of Ephesus, the site of Bronze Age Apasa, and the place to which the population withdrew when the Roman city failed. Christian writers of the second century say that John lived at Ephesus into the reign of Trajan, which began in AD 98, and was buried here. A small shrine stood over the grave by the fourth century.

In the mid-sixth century Justinian and Theodora replaced it with a church 130 metres long, laid out as a cross and roofed with six domes, on the model of the Church of the Holy Apostles in Constantinople. Their monograms are carved on the capitals. It was one of the great pilgrimage churches of the medieval world. Pilgrims collected a fine dust that was said to rise from the tomb each year on the saint's feast and to heal the sick.

The hill was fortified against Arab raids in the seventh and eighth centuries, using stone from the Roman stadium. Turks took the town in 1304. The basilica served briefly as a mosque, then as a market, and was a ruin by the fifteenth century. Partial restoration began in the twentieth century, paid for in part by American religious foundations.

THE PEOPLE

The medieval town was named for its saint: *Hagios Theologos*, the Holy Theologian, which Turkish speakers wore down to Ayasuluk. Under the Aydınid emirs of the fourteenth century it was a busy port again, home to Italian merchants, and the capital of a Turkish sea-raiding state. The İsa Bey Mosque at the foot of the hill, finished in 1375 by an architect from Damascus, stands on columns taken from Roman Ephesus. The town was renamed Selçuk in 1914.

POWER AND POLITICS

For Justinian the church was part of the same programme as Hagia Sophia: an empire reunited under one emperor and one orthodox faith, with the apostles' tombs as its holy places. Six centuries later the same coast was contested by the Byzantines, the Turkish emirates, the Knights Hospitaller on Rhodes and the fleets of Venice and Genoa, who fought the emirs one year and traded with them the next.

WORTH KNOWING

Ancient writers already debated which John lay here. Papias of Hierapolis distinguished John the apostle from another disciple, "John the elder", and the church historian Eusebius notes that two tombs at Ephesus bore the name. The tradition that honours this grave as the apostle's is nonetheless early and unbroken.

NEW TESTAMENT

John 19:26–27 · 21:20–24 · 1–3 John · Revelation 1:9 · compare Doctrine and Covenants 7 · 3 Nephi 28:6

The tradition that brought John here begins at the cross: "Behold thy mother! And from that hour that disciple took her unto his own home" (John 19:27). Second-century writers placed John at Ephesus in old age, and tradition connects his gospel, his three letters and Revelation with the city.

John 21:20–23 records Jesus' words, "If I will that he tarry till I come, what is that to thee?", and the rumour that followed that this disciple would not die. The rumour lived on here. Augustine, writing about 420, reported a story that John lay sleeping, not dead, in this tomb and that the dust above it stirred with his breath; he did not vouch for it. Latter-day Saint readers will connect the passage with Doctrine and Covenants 7 and 3 Nephi 28:6, which teach that John was allowed to remain on earth.

LOOK FOR

- The tomb, marked by four columns where the arms of the church cross
- The baptistery, with a keyhole-shaped pool and steps down on either side
- The Gate of Persecution at the entrance, built from reused Roman blocks
- The view west over the Artemision to the line of the ancient shore

23

The Carpet Village

A weaving centre, visited after Ephesus

DAY 8 · THU 22 OCT

The itinerary does not name the workshop, so this section covers the craft, which is one of the oldest continuous traditions in Anatolia.

HISTORY

Knotted pile carpets came to Anatolia with the Turkic peoples of Central Asia, for whom they were floor, furniture and wall. The oldest surviving Anatolian examples are thirteenth-century Seljuk carpets found in the Alaeddin Mosque at Konya, and Marco Polo, passing through in the 1270s, praised the carpets of the region as the finest in the world. By the fifteenth century they were being exported through Venice. Scholars still name early patterns after the European painters who showed them under the feet of saints and merchants, such as the "Holbein" and "Lotto" carpets.

Silk has a longer history here. Byzantium broke China's monopoly in the 550s, when, by Procopius's account, monks smuggled silkworm eggs to Justinian inside hollow canes. Under the Ottomans the city of Bursa became the centre of the silk trade, and in the 1840s the sultan founded an imperial workshop at Hereke to carpet Dolmabahçe Palace.

THE PEOPLE

Weaving was women's work, done at home between other tasks, and a girl's carpets were part of her dowry. The motifs form a vocabulary handed from mother to daughter: the figure with hands on hips for motherhood, the ram's horn for strength, the eye and the hook against envy, the tree of life. Village weavers work from memory, which is why no two pieces match.

Turkish carpets use the symmetrical or double knot, in which the yarn is wrapped around two warp threads. It is slower to tie than the Persian single knot and makes a sturdier fabric. A fine silk carpet can have more than a hundred knots to the square centimetre and take a weaver more than a year.

POWER AND POLITICS

Carpets were diplomatic currency. Sultans sent them to European courts, and Transylvanian churches still hold hundreds given by merchants who traded with the Ottomans. In the nineteenth century European and American demand turned a household craft into an export industry, run from Smyrna by foreign firms that supplied the designs and the dyes. Chemical dyes and factory spinning lowered quality. The cooperatives of the last few decades were set up to revive hand-spun wool, plant dyes and regional patterns, and to keep an income in the villages.

> **WORTH KNOWING**
>
> These visits are a demonstration followed by a showroom, and there is no obligation to buy. If you do, ask what the pile and the foundation are made of (wool on wool, wool on cotton, or silk), whether the dyes are natural, and get the price, the shipping terms and a certificate in writing.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · Acts 9:39 · 16:14 · 18:3 · John 19:23

Textile work runs through the New Testament. Lydia sold purple cloth (Acts 16:14). Paul, Aquila and Priscilla were tentmakers (Acts 18:3), a trade that worked woven goat hair and leather; Paul's home province of Cilicia gave its name to a goat-hair cloth. The widows at Joppa showed Peter "the coats and garments which Dorcas made" (Acts 9:39). The soldiers at the cross cast lots for Jesus' coat because it was "without seam, woven from the top throughout" (John 19:23).

IN PASSING ON DAY 9: IZMIR, ANCIENT SMYRNA

Revelation 1:11 · 2:8–11

The flight back to Istanbul leaves from Izmir, Turkey's third city. As Smyrna it was the second of the seven churches of Revelation, one of only two to receive no rebuke: "I know thy works, and tribulation, and poverty, (but thou art rich)" (Revelation 2:8–11). Its bishop Polycarp, by tradition a pupil of John, was burned in the stadium about AD 155. Smyrna remained the great port of the Aegean coast into modern times, with large Greek and Armenian communities, until the fire of September 1922 that destroyed its Christian quarters at the end of the Greek–Turkish war.

PART VI

DAY 9

Istanbul: Market and Strait

The last day turns from monuments to the two things that made the city rich and fought over: trade and the waterway.

24 The Spice Bazaar

Mısır Çarşısı, "the Egyptian Market"

DAY 9 · FRI 23 OCT

An L-shaped hall of vaulted shops built by a queen mother to pay for the mosque next door, at the quay where the cargoes of the eastern trade were landed.

HISTORY

The bazaar is one part of the New Mosque complex on the Golden Horn. Safiye Sultan, mother of Mehmed III, began the mosque in 1597, and it stood half-built for more than fifty years after her son's death. Turhan Sultan, mother of Mehmed IV, took the project up after a great fire in 1660 and finished mosque and market by 1665. The market's rents maintained the mosque.

It was first called the New Market or the Queen Mother's Market. The name "Egyptian" came later, either because it was built with the revenues of Egypt or because the spices sold in it came through Cairo. Its eighty-odd shops sold spices, drugs, dyes and perfumes. Coffee from Yemen had reached Istanbul a century earlier, and the city's first coffee-houses opened in the streets just behind the market in the 1550s. Turkish delight in its modern form dates from the late 1700s.

THE PEOPLE

The shopkeepers were *aktars*, herbalists who served as the city's pharmacists and mixed remedies to order. Their guild was among the most respected in the city.

The ground has an older story. In Byzantine times this shore was the Venetian merchants' quarter. Under the Ottomans it was a Jewish neighbourhood, and when the mosque was completed after the fire its residents were moved up the Golden Horn to make room. The two women who built the complex represent the height of what historians call the Sultanate of Women, a period of more than a century when the mothers of young or weak sultans effectively governed.

POWER AND POLITICS

The 1660s were years of recovery after a crisis. In the 1650s Venice, at war with the Ottomans over Crete, had blockaded the Dardanelles and caused food shortages and panic in the capital. Turhan's answer was to hand power to the Köprülü family of grand viziers, who restored order and finally took Crete in 1669.

There is an irony in the timing. The market was built on the profits of the old spice route through Egypt at the moment those profits were fading. Dutch and English ships were by then carrying most of Europe's pepper around Africa, and English and Dutch merchants were already established in Istanbul itself.

NEW TESTAMENT

Not named in the New Testament · Matthew 2:11 · Mark 16:1 · John 12:3 · 19:39–40 · Revelation 18:11–13

Almost every spice in the gospels is on these counters. The Magi brought "gold, and frankincense, and myrrh" (Matthew 2:11). Mary of Bethany anointed Jesus with "a pound of ointment of spikenard, very costly" (John 12:3). Nicodemus brought "a mixture of myrrh and aloes, about an hundred pound weight" for his burial (John 19:39), and the women came on Sunday morning with "sweet spices" (Mark 16:1). Revelation 18:11–13 lists the cargoes of a great trading city in terms a bazaar merchant would recognise: "gold, and silver, and precious stones, and of pearls, and fine linen, and purple, and silk, and scarlet … and cinnamon, and odours, and ointments, and frankincense, and wine, and oil".

LOOK FOR

- The New Mosque beside the market, with its tiled royal pavilion
- Outside the western gate, the queue for fresh-ground coffee at a roaster trading since 1871
- If time allows, the Rüstem Pasha Mosque (1563) three minutes' walk west, small and covered in the finest İznik tiles in the city

The Bosphorus

25

Dolmabahçe Palace · Rumeli Fortress · the strait between two continents

DAY 9 · FRI 23 OCT

Thirty kilometres of water joining the Black Sea to the Mediterranean and dividing Europe from Asia. The two landmarks on the cruise mark the beginning and the end of Ottoman Istanbul.

THE STRAIT

The Bosphorus is about thirty-one kilometres long and, at its narrowest, seven hundred metres wide. It carries two currents: on the surface, fresher water flows south from the Black Sea, and beneath it a salt current flows north. The Greeks explained the name as "ox-ford", from the myth of Io, who swam it in the form of a cow. Around 513 BC the Persian king Darius crossed it on a bridge of boats to invade Europe, at the narrows where the second road bridge now stands.

RUMELI FORTRESS

In the spring and summer of 1452 Mehmed II built this castle on the European shore in about four months, directly opposite an older Ottoman fort on the Asian side. He called it Boğazkesen, which means both "strait-cutter" and "throat-cutter". Three of his viziers each supervised one of the great towers and competed to finish

first. Its guns could now stop any ship. In November a Venetian captain who ignored the order to heave to was sunk, and he was executed. Constantinople was cut off from Black Sea grain and from help, and the siege began the following April. After the conquest the fortress had no military use and became a customs post and a prison.

DOLMABAHÇE PALACE

Four centuries later Sultan Abdülmecid I abandoned Topkapı for a European palace on the water. Dolmabahçe, the "filled-in garden", stands on a reclaimed bay and was built between 1843 and 1856 by Garabet Balyan and his son Nigoğayos. It has 285 rooms, a crystal staircase, a throne hall with a chandelier of four and a half tonnes, and tonnes of gold leaf on its ceilings. Six sultans lived here. Mustafa Kemal Atatürk used it as his Istanbul residence and died here on 10 November 1938 at 9:05 in the morning.

THE PEOPLE

The Balyans were an Armenian family who served as imperial architects for five generations and designed most of what you see from the boat: Dolmabahçe, the Ortaköy Mosque under the first bridge, and Beylerbeyi Palace on the Asian shore. The money came through the Greek, Armenian and Levantine bankers of Galata.

The villages along the strait were once distinct communities of Greek fishermen, Armenian craftsmen and Jewish traders, and several keep their churches and synagogues. Between them stand the *yalıs*, the wooden summer houses of Ottoman pashas, now some of the most expensive houses in the world.

POWER AND POLITICS

Dolmabahçe was a political statement. In 1839 the Ottoman government had begun the Tanzimat, a programme of European-style reform in law, the army and administration, and the palace declared that the empire was a modern European power. It was finished in the year the Crimean War ended, a war in which Britain and France fought beside the Ottomans to keep Russia from the straits. The barracks where Florence Nightingale nursed stand on the Asian shore opposite the old city.

The palace cost about a quarter of a year's state revenue. The empire took its first foreign loan in 1854, defaulted in 1875, and from 1881 European creditors collected a share of Ottoman taxes directly. The powers called the empire "the sick man of Europe" and argued over who would inherit the straits.

The question was settled here. In November 1918 an Allied fleet anchored off the palace. In November 1922 the last sultan slipped out and left on a British warship. The Montreux Convention of 1936 returned full control of the straits to Turkey: merchant ships pass freely, and the passage of warships is restricted. Turkey invoked it in 2022 to close the straits to the warships of states at war.

> **NEW TESTAMENT**
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> Acts 2:9 · 16:6–11 · 18:2 · 1 Peter 1:1
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> The Asian shore of the strait was the Roman province of Bithynia, and the Black Sea coast beyond it was Pontus. Paul was kept from preaching in Bithynia (Acts 16:7) and instead received the call "Come over into Macedonia, and help us" (16:9), which brought the gospel into Europe by sea further south. Pontus was

the home of Paul's colleague Aquila (Acts 18:2), and both provinces are named in 1 Peter 1:1, so the gospel reached them anyway.

About AD 112 Pliny the Younger, governor of Bithynia, wrote to the emperor Trajan asking what to do with the Christians of his province. His letter is the earliest description of Christian worship by an outsider: they met before dawn on a fixed day and sang a hymn "to Christ as to a god". Within a lifetime of 1 Peter, the communities it addressed had grown large enough to worry a Roman governor.

KEY DATES

c. 513 BC	Darius bridges the strait
1452	Rumeli Fortress built
1856	Dolmabahçe completed; Crimean War ends
1875	Ottoman state default
1922	The last sultan leaves
1936	Montreux Convention

LOOK FOR, FROM THE BOAT

- ◇ The 600-metre marble quay of Dolmabahçe, with its ceremonial sea gate
- ◇ The Ortaköy Mosque at the foot of the first Bosphorus bridge (1973)
- ◇ Rumeli Fortress climbing the hill beside the second bridge (1988), and the smaller Anatolian Fortress opposite
- ◇ The Maiden's Tower on its rock near the Asian shore

REFERENCE

Scripture finder

Every stop and its New Testament passages. Quotations in this guide follow the King James Version.

§	STOP	IN THE NT	PASSAGES
01	**Istanbul**	BACKGROUND	Acts 16:7–11 · Romans 16:9 · 1 Peter 1:1
02	**Çemberlitaş Hamamı**	BACKGROUND	legends link the column to Matthew 14:13–21 · Mark 14:3
03	**The Hippodrome**	BACKGROUND	1 Corinthians 9:24–27 · 2 Timothy 4:7–8 · Hebrews 12:1 · Acts 16:16 · 18:12
04	**Hagia Sophia**	BACKGROUND	1 Corinthians 1:24 · John 1:29 · John 8:12 · 20:19 · Colossians 1:15
05	**Topkapı Palace**	BACKGROUND	Mark 6:17–29 · Matthew 14:3–12 · John 14:27
06	**The Blue Mosque**	BACKGROUND	compare John 14:16 · 15:26
07	**The Basilica Cistern**	BACKGROUND	John 4:10–14 · 7:37–38 · Revelation 22:1, 17
08	**The Grand Bazaar**	BACKGROUND	Acts 16:14 · 17:17 · 18:3 · 19:24–27 · Revelation 2:18–29
09	**Hodjapasha and the Whirling Dervishes**	BACKGROUND	compare Luke 7:11–17 · John 3:3 · John 9 · John 11 · Galatians 2:20
10	**Kariye**	BACKGROUND	Matthew 1–2 · 25:31–46 · Luke 1–3 · John 2:1–11 · 1 Peter 3:18–20 · 4:6 · compare Doctrine and Covenants 138
11	**Cappadocia**	NAMED	Acts 2:9 · 1 Peter 1:1 · compare Doctrine and Covenants 138:5
12	**Derinkuyu Underground City**	BACKGROUND	Hebrews 11:38 · 1 Peter 4:12
13	**Avanos**	BACKGROUND	Romans 9:20–21 · 2 Corinthians 4:7 · 2 Timothy 2:20 · Revelation 2:27
14	**Göreme Open-Air Museum**	BACKGROUND	Gospel scenes from Matthew, Luke and John · Acts 1:9–11 · 2:44–45 · 4:32
15	**Uçhisar Castle**	BACKGROUND	John 2:1–11 · 15:1–5 · Luke 2:24 · Matthew 3:16
16	**Konya and the Mevlana Museum**	NAMED	Acts 13:51–14:6 · 14:21–23 · 16:1–5 · 2 Timothy 3:11 · Galatians 4:13
17	**Hierapolis and Pamukkale**	NAMED	Colossians 1:7 · 2:1 · 4:13 · Philip: John 1:43–46 · 6:5–7 · 12:20–22 · 14:8–9 · Acts 6:5 · Acts 8 · Acts 21:8–9
18	**Laodicea**	NAMED	Colossians 2:1 · 4:13–16 · Revelation 1:11 · 3:14–22
19	**Kuşadası**	BACKGROUND	Acts 20:13–17 · Revelation 1:9
20	**The Temple of Artemis**	NAMED	Acts 19:23–41 · compare Acts 17:24
21	**Ephesus**	NAMED	Acts 18:19–28 · Acts 19 · Acts 20:17–38 · 1 Corinthians 15:32 · 16:8–9 · Ephesians · 1 Timothy 1:3 · Revelation 1:11 · 2:1–7
22	**The Basilica of St John**	BACKGROUND	John 19:26–27 · 21:20–24 · 1–3 John · Revelation 1:9 · compare Doctrine and Covenants 7 · 3 Nephi 28:6
23	**The Carpet Village**	BACKGROUND	Acts 9:39 · 16:14 · 18:3 · John 19:23
—	**Izmir (Smyrna)**	NAMED	Revelation 1:11 · 2:8–11
24	**The Spice Bazaar**	BACKGROUND	Matthew 2:11 · Mark 16:1 · John 12:3 · 19:39–40 · Revelation 18:11–13

25 **The Bosphorus** BACKGROUND Acts 2:9 · 16:6–11 · 18:2 · 1 Peter 1:1

"Named" means the place itself appears in the New Testament; "Background" means it does not, and the section's note explains the connection. The other four churches of Revelation (Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis and Philadelphia) are not on this itinerary. Colossae, an unexcavated mound, lies about fifteen kilometres up the valley from Laodicea.

FURTHER READING

- **Mark Wilson,** *Biblical Turkey: A Guide to the Jewish and Christian Sites of Asia Minor*. The standard site-by-site handbook.
- **Bettany Hughes,** *Istanbul: A Tale of Three Cities*. The city from Byzantion to the Republic.
- **Judith Herrin,** *Byzantium: The Surprising Life of a Medieval Empire*. Good preparation for Hagia Sophia, Kariye and Göreme.
- **Caroline Finkel,** *Osman's Dream*. The Ottoman Empire from its beginnings to 1923.
- **Franklin Lewis,** *Rumi: Past and Present, East and West*. The fullest life of Rumi and history of his order.

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

Itinerary, dates and stops come from the tour operator's published page for the departure of 15 October 2026. Visitor arrangements at Hagia Sophia and Kariye and the finds at Laodicea and Hierapolis were checked against the sources below in October 2026; arrangements at working mosques can change at short notice. Early dates, ancient population figures and building capacities are estimates. The map uses Natural Earth public-domain data. This is an independent companion, not produced or endorsed by the tour operator.

- Bountiful Travel, "Highlights of Turkey with Brent L. Top (October 15, 2026)": bountifultravel.com/trips/highlights-of-turkey-2
- Hagia Sophia visitor route and ticketing: blog.wego.com/hagia-sophia-visitor-guide · istanbul.com/tr/hagia-sophia
- Kariye reopening and what is on view: istanbul.com/tr/kariye-mosque
- Laodicea church discovery: Biblical Archaeology Society, biblicalarchaeology.org
- Tomb of Philip at Hierapolis: *Biblical Archaeology Review* 38:1 (2012), old.biblicalarchaeology.org/node/123790